IELTS Reading: Question Types

All 11 question types, explained simply. Every example uses the same short passage, so you can compare how each type tests it. The last section lists what this means for the BandUp database.

1 The test in one minute

3	40	60	0–9
passages	questions	minutes, no extra time to copy answers	band score

- **Two versions:** *Academic* (university) and *General Training* (work or migration). Same question types, different texts.
- **Scoring:** each correct answer = 1 point. The raw score out of 40 is converted to a band. For example, in Academic about **30/40 ≈ band 7** and **23/40 ≈ band 6**. The exact table varies slightly from test to test.
- **Spelling counts.** A misspelled answer is wrong. Capital letters don't matter.
- **The instruction is a rule.** If it says "NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS", writing three words is wrong even if the meaning is right.

2 The example passage

A By the 1920s, grey wolves had been completely eliminated from Yellowstone National Park in the United States, largely through government-sponsored hunting. Without their main predator, elk populations expanded rapidly and overgrazed young willow and aspen trees along riverbanks.

B In 1995, fourteen wolves captured in Canada were released into the park, and a further seventeen followed the next year. Many scientists claim the outcome was a classic example of a "trophic cascade". As elk numbers fell, vegetation recovered, which provided habitat for beavers and songbirds.

C Nevertheless, this narrative has been challenged. Some ecologists point out that harsh winters, growing bear populations and human hunting also reduced elk numbers during the same period, making it difficult to attribute the changes to wolves alone.

3 The 11 types at a glance

#	Question type	Learner does…	BandUp code	Family
1	True / False / Not Given	judges a fact	`TFNG`	`choiceFixed`
2	Yes / No / Not Given	judges the writer's opinion	`YNNG`	`choiceFixed`
3	Multiple choice, one answer	picks 1 letter	`MCQ`	`mcSingle`
4	Multiple choice, several answers	picks 2–3 letters	`MCMA`	`mcMulti`
5	Matching headings	gives each paragraph a title	`MATCH_HEADINGS`	`match`
6	Matching information	finds which paragraph	`MATCH_INFO`	`match`
7	Matching features	links statements to people/things	`MATCH_FEATURES`	`match`
8	Matching sentence endings	finishes a sentence	`MATCH_ENDINGS`	`match`
9	Sentence completion	types words from the text	`FILL`	`gap`
10	Summary / note / table / flow-chart / diagram completion	fills gaps in a summary	`SUMMARY`	`gap`
11	Short answer	answers a question in a few words	`SHORT`	`gap`

Kind 1: Judge a statement

The answer is always one of three fixed words.

1. True / False / Not Given

`TFNG · choiceFixed`

Does the statement agree with the **facts** in the text?

TRUE	FALSE	NOT GIVEN
The text says the same thing.	The text says the *opposite*.	The text says *nothing* about it.

Do the following statements agree with the information in the passage? Write TRUE, FALSE or NOT GIVEN.

1. Wolves disappeared from Yellowstone mainly because of disease.
   → **FALSE**: the text says *hunting*. It names a different cause, so it contradicts the statement.
2. More wolves were released in the second year than in the first.
   → **TRUE**: 14 in the first year, 17 in the next. The learner has to compare the numbers.
3. The number of tourists increased after the wolves returned.
   → **NOT GIVEN**: tourists are never mentioned.

Why students fail: they confuse FALSE with NOT GIVEN, or use their own knowledge ("tourists probably increased"). Only the text counts. This is the type where good explanations help most.

2. Yes / No / Not Given

`YNNG · choiceFixed`

The same idea as TFNG, but about the **writer's opinion or claims**, not facts.

Do the following statements agree with the views of the writer? Write YES, NO or NOT GIVEN.

1. The writer believes wolves alone saved the ecosystem.
   → **NO**: the writer says it is "difficult to attribute the changes to wolves alone".
2. The writer thinks wolves should be reintroduced in Europe.
   → **NOT GIVEN**: Europe is never discussed.

Simple rule: TFNG is about facts, YNNG is about opinions. Usually seen with argument-style passages.

Kind 2: Pick from options

Each question has its own list of options (A, B, C, D…).

3. Multiple choice, one answer

`MCQ · mcSingle`

A question with 3–4 options. Exactly one is correct.

Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

What is the main purpose of the passage?

A. to praise government hunters
B. to show that a popular story is debated ✓
C. to describe wolves in Canada
D. to criticise all scientists

Trap: wrong options often use words copied from the text with a changed meaning.

4. Multiple choice, several answers

`MCMA · mcMulti`

The learner must choose a set number of letters ("Choose TWO").

Choose TWO letters, A–E.

According to some ecologists, which TWO things also reduced elk numbers?

A. disease **B. harsh winters ✓** C. tourists **D. bears ✓** E. floods

Scoring In the real test, "Choose TWO" usually counts as **2 questions** (e.g. Q7–8), and each correct letter earns 1 point in any order. B + A = 1 point, B + D = 2 points.

Kind 3: Matching

One shared list of options for the whole group of questions.

5. Matching headings

`MATCH_HEADINGS · match`

Choose the best title for each paragraph.

Choose the correct heading for each paragraph from the list of headings below.

List of headings

i. A surprising recovery
ii. Doubts about the evidence
iii. Why the wolves vanished
iv. The cost of tourism (extra, unused)
v. Life in Canada (extra, unused)

Answers

Paragraph A → **iii**
Paragraph B → **i**
Paragraph C → **ii**

Rule There are always **more headings than paragraphs** (distractors), and each heading is used **at most once**. Uses Roman numerals i, ii, iii.

6. Matching information

`MATCH_INFO · match`

"Which paragraph contains this information?" The options are the paragraph letters.

*Which paragraph contains the following information? **You may use any letter more than once.***

1. the number of animals brought into the park → **B**
2. other possible causes of a change → **C**
3. the reason a species disappeared → **A**
4. a scientific term for a chain of effects → **B** (B used twice, which is allowed)

Rule Unlike headings, a letter can be **reused**, and some paragraphs may not be used at all.

7. Matching features

`MATCH_FEATURES · match`

Match statements to a list of people, places, dates or categories.

Match each statement with the correct group, A–C. You may use any letter more than once.

Groups

A. government hunters
B. many scientists
C. some ecologists

Answers

1. called it a trophic cascade → **B**
2. questioned the wolf story → **C**
3. caused wolves to disappear → **A**

8. Matching sentence endings

`MATCH_ENDINGS · match`

Complete each sentence start with the correct ending from a list.

Complete each sentence with the correct ending, A–E.

Sentence starts	Endings
1. In 1995, wolves from Canada…	**A. were released into the park.** ← 1
2. When elk numbers fell,…	**B. plants grew back.** ← 2
	C. tourists left the park.
	D. bears disappeared.
	E. hunting was banned.

Trap: extra endings are grammatically correct but wrong in meaning.

Kind 4: Write words from the text

The learner types the answer, copied from the passage.

The word limit is part of the answer

Every group in this kind has a limit in its instruction, for example:

- "ONE WORD ONLY"
- "NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS"
- "NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS AND/OR A NUMBER" (so "17 wolves" is allowed)

Breaking the limit = wrong, even if the meaning is right. Words must be copied **from the text** and spelled correctly.

9. Sentence completion

`FILL · gap`

Complete a sentence with words from the passage.

Complete the sentences. Write ONE WORD ONLY from the passage.

1. Without wolves, too many elk damaged young trees near _____. → **riverbanks**
2. The recovery of plants created homes for beavers and _____. → **songbirds**
3. Critics say it is hard to give credit for the changes only to _____. → **wolves**

Skill tested: paraphrase. "near" = *along*, "homes" = *habitat*, "give credit to" = *attribute to*.

10. Summary / note / table / flow-chart / diagram completion

`SUMMARY · gap`

A short summary (or notes, a table, a flow chart, a labelled picture) with several gaps.

Version 1: words from the text. *NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS.*

After 1995, elk numbers **(1)** _____. As plants recovered, they provided **(2)** _____ for beavers and **(3)** _____.

→ (1) **fell** (2) **habitat** (3) **songbirds**

Version 2: words from a box. *Choose A–F.*

After 1995, elk numbers **(1)** _____. Plants provided **(2)** _____ for beavers.

A. rose B. **fell** C. food D. **habitat** E. danger F. water

→ (1) **B** (2) **D**, which works like *matching*

Diagram label completion is the same idea on a **picture** (for example, the parts of a machine or a cross-section of a river). It needs an image.

11. Short answer

`SHORT · gap`

A direct question with a short typed answer.

Answer the questions. Write NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS AND/OR A NUMBER.

1. Where were the released wolves captured? → **Canada**
2. How many wolves were released in total over the two years? → **31** (14 + 17)
3. Which trees did elk overgraze? (name one) → **willow** / **aspen** (both accepted)

Note: several answers can be correct ("willow" or "aspen"). That's why our database stores a *list* of accepted answers.

4 What this means for the BandUp database

The design supports all 11 types. The first five rules below have now been **added to the database design**. The last two come later, with full mock tests.

IELTS rule	Example	In the design
Word limit	"NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS AND/OR A NUMBER"	✅ `question_group.max_words` + `numbers_allowed`. Answers over the limit get 0 points.
Options reusable or not	Headings: once each. Matching info: "any letter more than once"	✅ `question_group.options_reusable`
Summary from a box	Gaps filled with letters A–F	✅ new type `SUMMARY_BOX` (match family: the box is the group option bank)
Diagram labels	A picture with blank labels	✅ `media` + `media_translation` tables, `question_group.media_id`, new type `DIAGRAM_LABEL`
Multi-answer scoring	"Choose TWO" = 2 points	✅ points per answer (`points_awarded` / `points_possible`); the question shows as Q7–8
Full test format	3 passages, 40 questions, 60 minutes	⏳ later: a `mock_test` table grouping 3 exercises
Band score	30/40 ≈ band 7 (Academic)	⏳ later: a `band_conversion` table (module, raw score → band)

> **Summary**
> All four kinds are now covered by the design, including word limits, reusable options, summary from a box, diagram images and "Choose TWO" scoring. Full mock tests and band scores are a later feature.